

ADVANCING FIRST CLASS PRE-K IN ALABAMA

Who Stays? Four Years of Teacher Turnover in First Class Pre-K

Annual and cumulative turnover among lead and auxiliary teachers, 2021–22 to 2025–26

JoonHo Lee and Alison Hooper ■ August 2026

Every fall, First Class Pre-K classrooms open with a mix of familiar and new faces, and we examine here how many of the previous year’s teachers returned to the program’s rosters. Because those rosters carry no stable staff identifier, we linked records across five school years, 2021–22 through 2025–26, resolving 14,674 roster records into roughly 5,200 individual teachers and 11,651 year-to-year transitions. Our analysis shows that in a typical year about one in five teachers is absent from the program’s rosters entirely, and about one in four is no longer at the same site. Following the teachers on a single year’s rosters, we observe that half of them are gone within three years.

We organize the evidence around four findings:

- **Annual departures.** The share of teachers absent from the next year’s rosters declined from 21.2 percent (2021–22 to 2022–23) to 17.7 percent (2024–25 to 2025–26), the lowest of the four transitions we observe (figure 1).
- **Cumulative retention.** Of the teachers on the 2021–22 rosters, 73.8 percent remained after one year, 59.8 percent after two, and 49.9 percent after three (figure 2).
- **Delivery setting.** The setting in which a teacher works is associated with the rate of departure: among lead teachers, program-exit rates range from 13.9 percent in university-operated class-

rooms to 32.6 percent in private-school settings (figure 3), and teachers in non-public settings overall left at 23.9 percent compared with 18.5 percent in public schools.

- **Linkage method.** How records are linked across years is associated with the rate a study reports, since matching teachers by name alone would overstate the most recent exit rate as 19.1 percent instead of 17.7. Because that error is twice as common in non-public settings, we base the rates in this brief on multi-key identity resolution (figure 4).

These are descriptive counts drawn from administrative rosters, a census of the program’s own records rather than a sample, and we return at the end of the brief to what “leaving” does and does not mean.

Teacher Continuity and Program Quality

Alabama’s pre-K reputation rests on classroom standards: credentialed teachers, small classes, and sustained coaching. Each of those standards is easier to maintain with a stable workforce, because every departure sets off a familiar sequence—recruitment, credential review, and a coaching restart—while every new hire spends a first year on the learning curve. Although the standards themselves are written in terms of classrooms, they are delivered by individual adults, and for children continuity carries an even simpler meaning: whether the adults who greet them in August are still there in May, and still in the program when a younger sibling arrives.

In this brief, the sixth in the *Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama* series, we establish the workforce baseline; a companion brief takes up the compensation structures that sit behind it.

BOX 1

Data and Methods

Data. We use First Class Pre-K staff rosters for school years 2021–22 through 2025–26, assembled by The University of Alabama team under the ADECE partnership. Because the rosters carry no stable staff identifier, we linked records across years by resolving names (with normalization for name changes), dates of birth, and credential numbers into persistent identities, yielding 14,674 roster records, 5,235 identities, and 11,651 year-to-year transitions. All rates in this brief use those 11,651 transitions as the denominator.

What counts as leaving. We treat a teacher as having “left the program” when she appears on no First Class Pre-K roster the following year. Those absences include moves to K–12 and other early-childhood settings, moves out of state, and temporary leaves, so the measure records departure from this program rather than departure from teaching. “Leaving the site” additionally counts moves between First Class sites.

Measures. Our results describe the full roster census, and no sampling is involved. We report rates for groups of at least five transitions and never report site-level rates, because most sites have one or two lead teachers and a single site's annual rate is therefore statistically meaningless. All results are descriptive and support no causal claims.

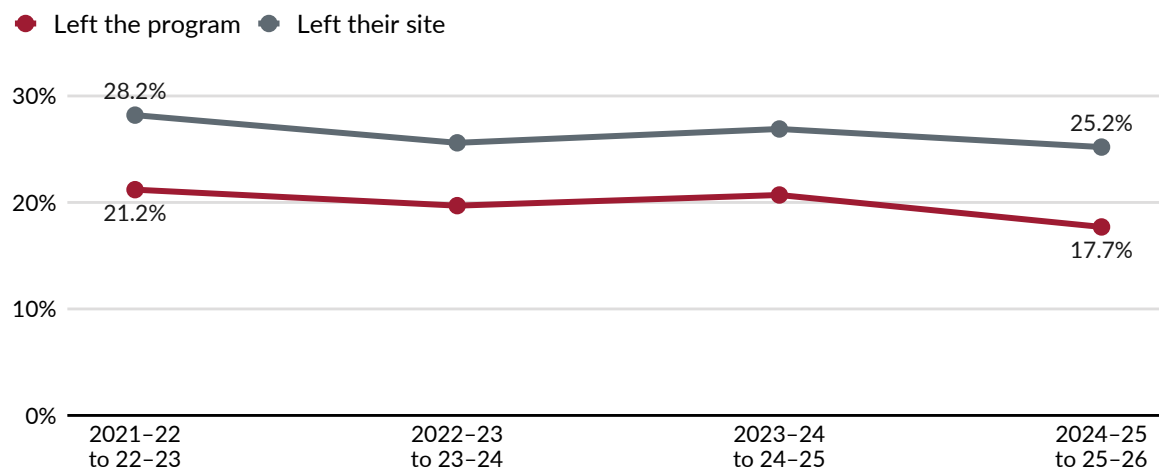
Annual Departures from the Program

Across the four observed transitions, between 17.7 and 21.2 percent of teachers on a given year's rosters were absent from the next year's, and between 25.2 and 28.2 percent were no longer at the same site (figure 1). The gap between the two lines measures movement within the program, consisting of teachers who change sites while remaining in First Class Pre-K.

FIGURE 1

Departures Have Eased over the Four Observed Transitions

Share of lead and auxiliary teachers leaving, by year-to-year transition, 2021–22 to 2025–26



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 to 2025–26.

Notes: ADECE = Alabama Department of Early Childhood Education. "Left the program" means absent from the next year's rosters; "left their site" additionally includes moves between First Class sites. Each transition covers 2,738–3,023 teacher-year records.

The direction of change is encouraging, in that the most recent transition, from 2024–25 to 2025–26, posted the lowest program-exit rate of the four at 17.7 percent. That decline may reflect recent state salary-schedule changes, a broader cooling of the labor market, or both, and a descriptive brief cannot distinguish among those explanations. Although the trend points downward, the level remains high, since even at 17.7 percent a site with nine teachers can expect to replace one or two of them each year.

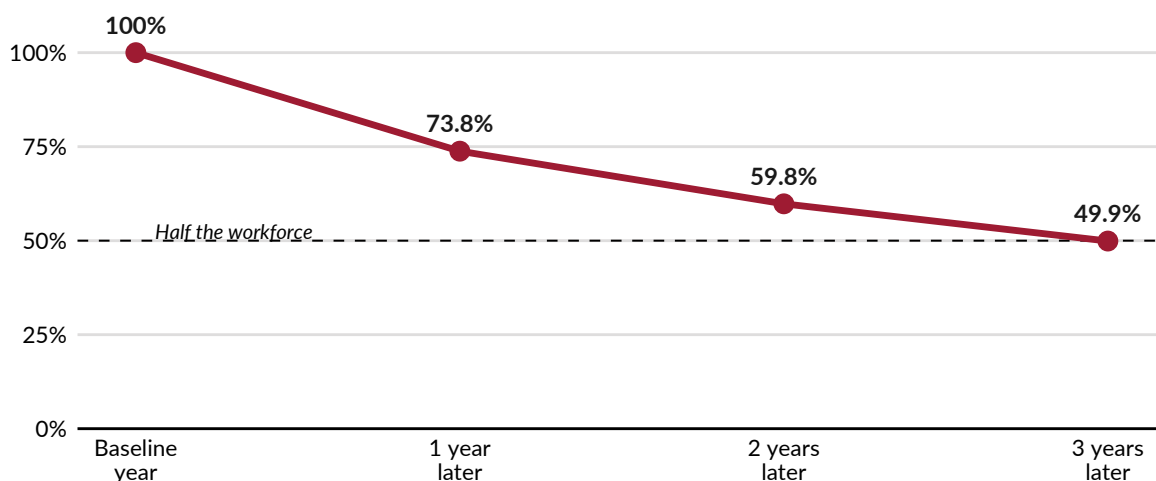
Cumulative Retention over Three Years

Annual rates understate what turnover does over time, because departures compound from one year to the next. Tracking the teachers who appear on the 2021–22 rosters, we observe that 73.8 percent were still in the program one year later, 59.8 percent after two years, and 49.9 percent after three (figure 2).

FIGURE 2

Half of the 2021–22 Teaching Workforce Was Gone within Three Years

Share of 2021–22 lead and auxiliary teachers still on First Class Pre-K rosters, by years elapsed



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 to 2025–26.

Notes: Retention is measured against the 2021–22 roster cohort; teachers who return after a gap year are counted as retained in the years they appear.

A program that loses half its teachers every three years must continuously rebuild the experience base its quality model assumes, and a child entering a classroom faces roughly even odds that the teacher in it was not in the program three years earlier. Because the annual and cumulative measures describe the same departures on different time scales, the cumulative measure is likely the more useful of the two for workforce planning.

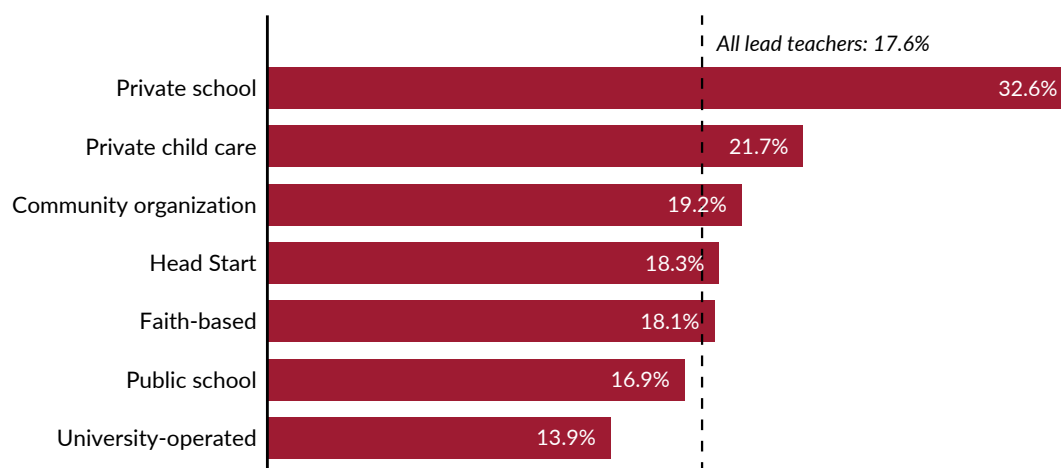
Turnover across Delivery Settings

First Class Pre-K operates through a mixed delivery system, and the setting in which a teacher works is associated with the rate at which teachers leave. Among lead teachers, university-operated classrooms lose 13.9 percent of their teachers to program exit in a typical transition and public schools 16.9 percent, while community organizations (19.2), private child care (21.7), and private schools (32.6) run higher (figure 3).

FIGURE 3

University and Public-School Classrooms Hold Their Teachers Best

Share of lead teachers leaving the program, by delivery type, pooled 2021–22 to 2025–26



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 to 2025–26.

Notes: Lead teachers only; pooled across the four transitions. Group sizes range from 43 transitions (private school) to 4,395 (public school)—the private-school estimate is correspondingly less precise.

Pooling all teachers, working in a non-public setting is associated with a program-exit rate of 23.9 percent, compared with 18.5 percent in public schools. Some of that difference could in principle be a counting artifact, because non-public rosters are harder to link across years. Although that concern is a reasonable one, in the subset of transitions where linkage quality can be directly audited the raw gap of 4.7 percentage points narrows only to 4.3 after correcting for measurable linkage error, leaving measurement to account for roughly 8 percent of it. The sector difference therefore does not appear to reflect how the records were counted, but rather how the program is staffed across settings. Brief 8 documents the compensation differences that sit alongside it.

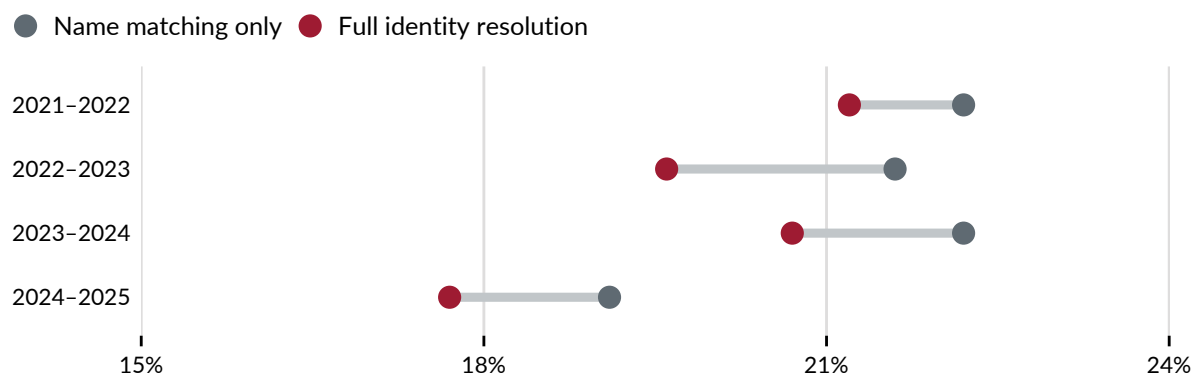
How Records Are Linked across Years

Any turnover statistic depends on how a study establishes that last year's Ms. Smith is this year's Ms. Smith. Because First Class rosters carry no stable staff identifier, and because names change—marriage being the common case—matching on names alone misclassifies teachers who stayed as teachers who left. Doing so would place the most recent exit rate at 19.1 percent instead of 17.7 (figure 4), and because the linkage failures fall twice as often on non-public settings, at 0.8 versus 0.4 percent of transitions, they inflate exactly the comparisons policymakers care about.

FIGURE 4

Name-Only Matching Overstates Every Year's Exit Rate

Program-exit rate under name-only matching versus full identity resolution, by transition



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021-22 to 2025-26.

Notes: "Full identity resolution" links records on normalized names, dates of birth, and credential numbers; rates here come from the linkage-sensitivity audit and can differ from figure 1 by up to 0.1 point of rounding. A technical companion paper documents the method and its sensitivity analysis.

Readers comparing turnover rates across states or studies may therefore want to ask how identities were linked before treating two figures as comparable, because rates built on raw name matching run high and do so unevenly across settings.

Discussion

These patterns suggest that retention targets set on the annual rate may understate the size of the planning problem. An annual departure rate near 20 percent can sound tolerable, whereas the finding that half a cohort is gone within three years names the workforce arithmetic that expansion plans currently lack, since every new classroom would have to be staffed *net of* replacement hiring. If the program were to adopt explicit retention goals, the cumulative measure is likely the more informative basis for setting them.

Moreover, the exit-rate differences associated with delivery setting would support sector-targeted responses. Because the contrast between public and non-public settings survives correction for measurable linkage error, options concentrated in non-public settings, such as compensation floors, benefits access, or greater coaching intensity, would address the part of the system where churn is concentrated. Brief 8 takes up the pay and benefits structures behind this gap.

Finally, our experience assembling these estimates points to a data improvement that would make them routine. Reconstructing careers from names and credentials took a research team months, whereas a persistent staff identifier in the program's data system would allow retention monitoring to

be accurate, repeatable, and free of the measurement hazards documented here. Among the changes that might strengthen the program's evidence base, this one is possibly the least expensive.

Limitations

These analyses have several limitations. Leaving the program is not the same as leaving teaching, because exits include moves to kindergarten classrooms, other early-childhood programs, and other states, and these data cannot separate those destinations. Rosters are annual snapshots, so mid-year departures and arrivals between roster dates are not observed. The rates we report describe the census of records rather than a sample, and they characterize what the rosters show under a documented linking procedure that internal consistency checks, but not ground truth, support. Finally, nothing reported here estimates why teachers leave or the effect of any policy on retention.

The description is nonetheless a necessary starting point, because a program whose quality case rests on its teachers replaces a fifth of them each year and half every three, at rates that differ by setting in ways measurement error does not appear to explain.

References

Lee, JoonHo, and Alison Hooper. 2026. "Who Stayed? Consistency-Checking Longitudinal Identity Resolution and the Sensitivity of Teacher Turnover Estimates." Working paper. Tuscaloosa: University of Alabama.

About the Authors

JoonHo Lee is an Assistant Professor of Education Research at The University of Alabama. He earned his Ph.D. in Quantitative Methods and Evaluation from the University of California, Berkeley. As a Bayesian statistician, he translates methodological innovation into actionable insights on early childhood policy and school finance reform.

Alison Hooper is an Associate Professor of Early Childhood Education at The University of Alabama. She received her Ph.D. in Human Development and Family Studies from the University of Delaware. A former kindergarten and preschool teacher, her research focuses on child care and early education access and quality and educator well-being.

Acknowledgments

This brief is part of the Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project, conducted by The University of Alabama in partnership with the Alabama Department of Early Childhood Education (ADECE). We are grateful to ADECE and the Office of School Readiness for making the staff roster data available and for their partnership. ADECE reviewed the data provided but has not reviewed or endorsed the analyses or conclusions, which are the authors' alone and should not be attributed to ADECE or to The University of Alabama. Any errors are our own.

ABOUT THIS PROJECT

The Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project examines First Class Pre-K funding, implementation, access, and comparisons with other state pre-K programs. Its goal is to offer recommendations for expanding First Class Pre-K while maintaining high levels of quality.

Copyright © August 2026. Permission is granted for reproduction of this file, with attribution to The University of Alabama Early Education Research Office.